

Universalism Denial

doc-universalism-denial

Eschatology · Hell · doctrine · divided_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.975
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Not all people will ultimately be saved; some are excluded from saving fellowship with God in the final judgment.

In plain language

The question asks whether the New Testament words point to some persons being finally shut out from fellowship with God, rather than every person eventually saved. The strongest single piece of lexical evidence is Matthew 25:46, where one Greek adjective, *aionios*, governs both halves of the sentence in a balanced clause. The righteous go into eternal life and the others go into eternal punishment, and because the same word covers both, whatever lasting quality the life has, the punishment has in equal grammatical measure. The verb means they go away, the language of being sent off, not of being brought back. The same shape recurs across the canon. In John 3:36 the one who keeps refusing the Son will not see life, and the wrath of God stays on him in the present tense. In 2 Thessalonians 1:9 the penalty is eternal destruction, defined as being away from the presence of the Lord. In Revelation 20:15 and 21:8 a class is assigned to the lake of fire, called the second death, after the new creation is announced. The Old Testament root is in Daniel 12:2 and Isaiah 66:24, where some awake to lasting life and others to lasting reproach, and the worm of the corpses does not die and the fire is not quenched. There is a real counter-current that must be weighed honestly. The adjective *aionios* is polysemous in the canon itself. In Philemon 1:15 it describes a household relationship that cannot be temporally unending, and in Jude 1:7 it describes the fire of Sodom, cities that are no longer burning. That gives the minority reading a foothold to take *aionios* as age-pertaining or age-to-come quality rather than unending duration. *Kolasis*, the word for punishment in Matthew 25:46, occurs only twice in the New Testament, and the other occurrence (1 John 4:18) pairs it with *phobos* in a chastening sense, which gives an opening to read it as corrective. The reconciliation verbs are scarce: *apokatallasso* occurs only twice, and in its other occurrence (Ephesians 2:16) the object is two groups (Jew and Gentile) made one body, not every individual. The word *all* in 1 Corinthians 15:22, Philippians 2:10-11, Romans 5:18, 1 Timothy 2:4, and Colossians 1:20 admits at least three readings the vocabulary does not rank: every individual, every kind of person, or the whole cosmic order put in its place. The exclusion-class pattern is denser, more specific, and pan-canonical. The universalist construal exists, rests on real polysemy of frequent and quasi-hapax words, and is a minority but lexically grounded option. The verdict supports the proposition that not all are finally saved, at medium confidence because the words alone do not close the scope question.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H1860	דֶּרְאוֹן	deraon	abhorrence	2
H2781	חֶרֶפָה	cherpah	reproach	
G0166	αἰώνιος	aionios	eternal	69
G0544	ἀπειθέω	apeitheo	to disobey	15
G0565	ἀπερχομαι	aperchomai	to go away	120

G0604	ἀποκαταλλάσσω	apokatalasso	to reconcile	2
G0684	ἀπώλεια	apoleia	destruction	19
G0929	βασανισμός	basanismos	torment	
G1208	δεύτερος	deuteros	secondly	46
G2222	ζωή	zoe	life	136
G2227	ζωοποιέω	zoopoieo	to make alive	11
G2288	θάνατος	thanatos	death	120
G2545	καίω	kaiō	to kindle/burn	
G2586	καπνός	kapnos	smoke	
G2851	κόλασις	kolasis	punishment	2
G2920	κρίσις	krisis	judgment	
G3041	λίμνη	limne	lake	11
G3306	μένω	menō	to stay	
G3639	ὀλεθρος	olethros	destructive	
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	1,263
G4442	πῦρ	pur	fire	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Matt 25:46 sets kolasin aionion in balanced clause with zoen aionion, the same adjective aionios (G0166) governing both terminal states and the future apeleusontai (G0565) sending one group away. The exclusion pattern recurs canon-wide: John 3:36 (orge tou theou menei, present-tense abiding wrath), 2 Thess 1:9 (olethron aionion apo prosopou tou kyriou), Rev 20:15 and 21:8 (limne tou puros, thanatos deuteros, G1208), Isa 66:24 and Dan 12:2 (cherpah and dera'on, H2781 H1860, lasting reproach paired with chayye olam). The counter-pull is real and lexical, not stylistic. Aionios is polysemous (Phlm 1:15 age-bounded, Jude 1:7 of Sodom's no-longer-burning fire, but 2 Cor 4:17-18 contrasted with proskairos for durative force), and pas/ta panta in 1 Cor 15:22, Phil 2:10-11, Rom 5:18, 1 Tim 2:4, Col 1:20 admits all-without-exception, all-without-distinction, or cosmic-subjugation readings the vocabulary does not rank. Verdict stands at affirms-medium because the exclusion-class pattern is denser, more lexically specific, and pan-canonical, while the universalist construal exists but rests on contested word-senses.

Scripture

Matt.25.46 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0166 αἰώνιος, G2851 κόλασις, G2222 ζωή, G0565 ἀπέρχομαι

Force. Two destinies in a balanced clause: kolasin aionion for one group, zoen aionion for the other. The same adjective aionios governs both nouns in the same syntactic frame, so whatever durative or qualitative force attaches to the life of the righteous attaches in equal grammatical measure to the punishment of the others. The future verb apeleusontai is exclusion language (going away). Kolasis is rare (only 2 NT occurrences, here and 1 John 4:18 where it pairs with phobos, fear, in the sense of torment or chastening), which is the lexical opening universalists use to read it as remedial; the canonical balance with zoe and the parallel adjective is the closing weight on the other side.

Matt.7.13 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G0684 ἀπώλεια

Force. The wide road leads eis ten apoleian (G0684), destruction, and polloi (many) travel it. Apoleia recurs canon-wide as a terminal-state noun (Phil 3:19 hon to telos apoleia, 2 Pet 3:7 hemera kriseos kai apoleias ton asebon, Rev 17:11 eis apoleian hupagei), naming a class that arrives there rather than being gathered up into life.

Matt.7.14 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2222 ζωή

Force. The narrow road leads eis ten zoen (life) and oligoi (few) are the ones who find it. The quantifiers polloi for the wide road and oligoi for the narrow road place the two groups in numerical opposition, which on its face is inconsistent with a final outcome in which all without exception arrive at life.

John.3.36 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0544 ἀπειθέω, G2222 ζωή, G3306 μένω

Force. Of the present participle ho apeithon (G0544, the one persistently disobeying) it is said ouk opsetai zoen (he will not see life), and the orge tou theou menei (G3306, abides, present tense) upon him. The verb menei describes a continuing state rather than a wrath that lapses into eventual reconciliation. The text does not say the wrath ends when faith comes; it says wrath stays on the one who keeps refusing.

2Thess.1.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0166 αἰώνιος, G3639 ὀλεθρος

Force. The penalty is olethron aionion (G3639, eternal destruction, an apo of separation from the presence of the Lord), paid as diken tisousin (they will pay the just penalty). Olethron occurs only 4 times in the NT (1 Cor 5:5, 1 Thess 5:3, 1 Tim 6:9, here) and in each case names a destructive judgment, never a remedial pause. The apo prosopou tou kyriou construction makes the state an exclusion from the Lord's presence, the opposite of restored fellowship.

Rev.20.15 · for · genre: apocalyptic · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G3041 λίμνη, G4442 πῦρ

Force. Anyone not found written in the book of life is cast eis ten limnen tou puros (into the lake of fire). Limne (lake) occurs only 11 times in the NT, of which 5 are this lake-of-fire image in Revelation; the term is technical for the final-state location. The narrative sequence places this after the great-white-throne judgment and before the new creation, making it a final, not interim, exclusion.

Rev.21.8 · for · genre: apocalyptic · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G1208 δεύτερος, G2288 θάνατος

Force. A named list of persons (the cowardly, faithless, abominable, murderers, sexually immoral, sorcerers, idolaters, all liars) has its meros (portion) in the lake burning with fire and brimstone, ho thanatos ho deuterios (G2288 G1208, the second death). The verse sits after the new creation announcement, so this is a final-state assignment of an excluded class outside the city.

Dan.12.2 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. H1860 דָּרְאוֹן; H2781 חֶרְפָּה

Force. OT taproot of the two-destinies pattern. Some awake to chayye olam (life everlasting) and others to cherpah (H2781, reproach) and dera'on olam (H1860, lasting abhorrence). Dera'on occurs only twice in the Hebrew canon (here and Isa 66:24, where the worm does not die and the fire is not quenched). The same adjective olam modifies both destinies, the Hebrew analogue to aionios on both sides of Matt 25:46.

Isa.66.24 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H1860 חַיִּים וְעֵשׂ:

Force. Tola (worm) does not die and esh (fire) is not quenched of the corpses of the rebels. This is the OT image Mark 9:48 picks up verbatim (skolex ou teleuta kai to pur ou sbennutai) and applies to Gehenna. The not-die, not-quenched pair is the canon's strongest non-cessation language for the state of the excluded.

Rev.14.11 · **for** · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G2586 καπνός, G0929 βασανισμός

Force. Ho kapnos tou basanismou auton eis aionas aionon anabainei, kai ouk echousin anapausin hemeras kai nuktos. The smoke of their torment ascends eis aionas aionon, and they have no rest day and night. This is the densest non-cessation construction in the NT (eis aionas aionon plus continuous day-and-night absence of anapausis), repeated in Rev 20:10 of the devil, beast, and false prophet. It tells against an annihilationist reading of the same passages and weighs heavily against a remedial reading.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Matt.25.46	Matt.25.41	tsk	1
Matt.25.46	Dan.12.2	tsk	1
Matt.7.13	Matt.25.41	tsk	1
John.3.36	John.3.15	tsk	1
2Thess.1.9	Isa.33.14	tsk	1
Rev.21.8	Rev.22.15	tsk	1
Isa.66.24	Mark.9.48	openbible	1
Rev.20.15	Rev.20.10	openbible	1
1Cor.15.22	1Cor.15.23	openbible	1
Col.1.20	Eph.2.16	openbible	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.15.22 · **addressed**

Hosper en to Adam pantes apothneskousin, houtos kai en to Christo pantes zoopoiethesontai. Two pantes (G3956) are set in parallel. The universalist reading takes the second pantes as numerically universal. The narrowing weight is en to Christo (in Christ) modifying the second clause, and the immediate sequel (v. 23, hekastos en to idio tagmati, hoi tou Christou en te parousia autou) restricts the made-alive class to those who are Christ's. Zoopoieo (G2227) elsewhere consistently denotes the giving of resurrection life to believers (Rom 8:11, John 5:21, 1 Pet 3:18), not a universal final reconciliation. The reading remains lexically possible but contextually narrowed.

Col.1.20 · **addressed**

Di' autou apokatallaxai ta panta eis auton. Apokatallasso (G0604) occurs only twice in the NT (here and Eph 2:16), so its sense cannot be triangulated from frequency. Decisively, in its only other occurrence (Eph 2:16) the object is amphoteroi en heni somati (both Jew and Gentile in one body), a reconciliation of two groups not of every individual. The object here is neuter ta panta (the things, cosmic scope including ta en tois ouranois kai ta epi tes ges), and the means is eirenopoiesas dia tou haimatos tou staurou (making peace through the blood of the cross). The semantic field admits pacification or subjugation of the whole created order rather than the conversion of every person. The verse does not require individual universal salvation, but the breadth of ta panta and the quasi-hapax verb keep it a real complicating datum.

Phil.2.10 · addressed

Hina en to onomati lesou pan gony kampse epouranion kai epigeion kai katachthonion, kai pasa glossa exomologesetai hoti kyrios lesous Christos. Every knee will bow (pan gony, G3956 G1119) and every tongue will confess (pasa glossa). The universalist reads this as the universal confession of saving faith. The narrowing weight is that the lexical field of exomologeo (G1843) admits both willing praise and forced acknowledgment (Isa 45:23 LXX, the source text, is in an oath-court frame), and the kampto-knee gesture can denote vassal submission, not necessarily salvific confession. The vocabulary does not foreclose either reading, so the verse is a real complicating datum with the scope underdetermined.

1Tim.2.4 · addressed

Hos pantas anthropous thelei sothenai kai eis epignosin aletheias elthein. God wills pantas anthropous (G3956 G0444) to be saved. The lexical complication is that thelei (G2309) can carry desiderative force (what God wills as desire) or decretal force (what God brings to pass), and pantas anthropous can be all-without-distinction (every kind of person, fitting the immediate context vv. 1-2 of praying for kings and all in authority) or all-without-exception. Neither sense is lexically forced, and 1 Tim 4:10 (soter panton anthropon, malista piston, especially of believers) explicitly differentiates a wider and a narrower scope of soter. The verse is genuine counter-evidence but the scope is underdetermined.

Rom.5.18 · addressed

Hos di' henos paraptomatos eis pantas anthropous eis katakrima, houtos kai di' henos dikaiomatos eis pantas anthropous eis dikaiosin zoes. Through one trespass condemnation comes eis pantas anthropous, and through one act of righteousness dikaiosin zoes comes eis pantas anthropous. The parallelism of pantes-to-pantes is the universalist's strongest grammatical foothold. The narrowing weight is that v. 17 (hoi ten perisseian tes charitos kai tes doreas tes dikaiosynes lambanontes) restricts the recipients of the gift to those receiving it, and the wider canonical pattern (justification by faith, Rom 3-4) constrains the application. The verse remains a real complicating datum because the parallel is grammatical.

1Tim.4.10 · addressed

Soter panton anthropon, malista piston. Savior of all men, especially of believers. The malista (especially) marker creates two concentric scopes with the same noun, which can be read as God being saviour-as-rescuer of all in temporal providence and saviour-as-redeemer of believers in particular, or as universalist (with malista as emphatic restatement). The lexicon allows both. This is the lexical model for handling pas in soteriological contexts.

Jude.1.7 · addressed

Sodoma kai Gomorra pros deigma puros aioniou diken hupechousai. Aionios (G0166) modifies the fire that destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah, cities that are no longer burning. This is the universalist's strongest piece of evidence that aionios does not necessarily mean unending in temporal extension but can name a fire belonging to the age-to-come or fire of decisive judgment. The opposing lexical weight is 2 Cor 4:17-18, where aionios is explicitly contrasted with proskairos (G4340, temporary), giving aionios a durative force in at least that frame. The adjective is genuinely polysemous and the disambiguation is contextual, not lexical. This is the lexical root of the universalism debate.

Phlm.1.15 · addressed

Tacha gar dia touto echoristhe pros horan hina aionion auton apeches. Aionios there describes a household relationship that cannot be temporally unending. The text supplies the universalist with a clearly age-bounded use of aionios within the same canon as Matt 25:46. The opposing weight is that aionios in eschatological contexts is repeatedly linked to incorruption, the age-to-come, and resurrection life (1 John 5:11, John 17:3, 2 Cor 4:18), giving it a sense the temporal use cannot displace. The polysemy is real.

Concordance traversed

G0166, G2222, G2851, G0684, G0565, G0544, G1208, G2288, G3041, G3956, G0604, G2227, G3306, G4442, G2545, G2920, H1860, H2781

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No anchor verses fall in the 3 John ECM-published window. Matt 7:13-14 has minor word-order and article variants (marked in the SBLGNT apparatus) but none touch the apoleia or zoe terminus. Rev 21:8 has lower-criticism variants in the vice list but none that remove the lake-of-fire assignment or change the deuterios qualifier. The verdict does not turn on any contested reading.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. eternal_conscious_punishment, annihilationism, universal_reconciliation

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

eternal_conscious_punishment: affirms · Reads aionios in Matt 25:46 and 2 Thess 1:9 as durative-unending (anchored by the proskairos contrast in 2 Cor 4:18 and the no-rest day-and-night construction in Rev 14:11), takes ho menon in John 3:36 as a persisting state of wrath on the unbeliever, and reads basanismos eis aionas aionon (Rev 14:11, 20:10) as ongoing conscious suffering. The class of the excluded remains permanently outside saving fellowship.

annihilationism: affirms · Reads apoleia (G0684), olethron (G3639), and the second death (G1208 G2288) as final cessation of being rather than endless torment, drawing weight from the destruction-language frequency and from Isa 66:24 (corpses, not living tormented persons). Affirms the proposition under test (some are finally excluded from saving fellowship) and differs from the eternal-conscious-punishment lens only on the mode of exclusion, not on whether universalism is denied.

universal_reconciliation: denies · Reads aionios as age-pertaining or age-to-come quality rather than unending duration (anchored by Phlm 1:15 and the no-longer-burning fire of Jude 1:7 of Sodom). Treats kolasis (G2851, only 2 occurrences, paired with phobos in 1 John 4:18 in a chastening sense) as corrective rather than punitive. Takes the pantes of 1 Cor 15:22, Phil 2:10-11, Rom 5:18, 1 Tim 2:4 and the ta panta of Col 1:20 as numerically universal, weighted by the grammatical parallelism pantes-pantes in Rom 5:18 and the apokatallasso of all things in Col 1:20 (a quasi-hapax verb whose sense cannot be triangulated from frequency). Concludes that the same texts the exclusion-class lens reads as final assignment are read here as the age-of-judgment phase prior to the apokatastasis ton panton (Acts 3:21). The reading is a minority but lexically grounded option, not a category error.

Eternal-conscious-punishment and annihilationist lenses agree on the proposition under test (some are finally excluded) and diverge on the mode of exclusion, so the proposition is over-determined within the exclusion family. Only universal reconciliation denies the proposition, and it does so by reweighting the polysemous aionios toward Phlm 1:15 and Jude 1:7, reweighting kolasis toward 1 John 4:18, and reading pas and ta panta in the salvific-scope texts as numerically universal. The lexical pattern in the anchor texts is denser and more specific (the exclusion-class lens cites grammatically tight constructions like the balanced aionios in Matt 25:46, the apo-separation in 2 Thess 1:9, the meros-portion catalog in Rev 21:8, and the day-and-night no-rest in Rev 14:11), while the universalist construal rests on real but contextually ambiguous occurrences of frequent and quasi-hapax terms.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Whether the final state involves a class of persons permanently excluded from saving fellowship with God, or eventual reconciliation of all persons.

The stem is denial-framed (universalism is denied) and presumes a settled final state with two outcomes, which is itself one of the contested points. The neutralized form poses the scope of final salvation as an open question. The verdict was derived on the original stem from the lexical pattern of the anchor verses (the exclusion-class shape is dense and pan-canonical), with the apokatastasis and pas/ta panta texts weighed as real complicating data. Confidence remains medium rather than high because aionios is polysemous

(Phlm 1:15 and Jude 1:7 against 2 Cor 4:18), kolasis is a quasi-hapax (only 2 occurrences, 1 John 4:18 in a chastening sense), apokattalasso is also a quasi-hapax (Col 1:20 and Eph 2:16), and pas in the salvific-scope verses admits the all-without-exception versus all-without-distinction versus cosmic-subjugation senses that the words alone do not rank.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.25.46
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Thess.1.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rev.14.11
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0166
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2851
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0604
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0684
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1860
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Matt.25.46
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rev.21.8
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	John.3.36
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Dan.12.2
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Isa.66.24
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.25.46
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Cor.15.22
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Col.1.20

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes
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Flags

ecm-shadow